

Courts could thwart Texas

Judges can't review gerrymandering — unless it violates Voting Rights Act.

By MICHAEL WILNER AND ANITA CHABRIA

California is in a standoff with Texas over redistricting that could decide the balance of power in Congress for the end of Donald Trump's presidency — a high-stakes gambit with risks for both sides. But if the courts have their say, Texas, facing accusations of racial discrimination, may find itself at a distinct legal disadvantage.

Both efforts by Texas Republicans and California Democrats are blatantly partisan, proposing a mid-decade redrawing of district lines for the express purpose of benefiting their party in the 2026 midterm elections.

California Gov. Gavin Newsom is working with a Democratic supermajority in the Legislature on "trigger" legislation that would schedule a ballot initiative this fall for the new maps. It was a direct response to a Texas plan, supported by Trump and currently in motion in the Austin statehouse, to potentially flip five seats in the upcoming election from blue to red.

The Supreme Court has ruled that judges are powerless to review partisan gerrymandering, even if, as it wrote in 2019, the practice is "incompatible with democratic principles."

The court ruled in *Rucho vs. Common Cause* that partisan gerrymandering "is incompatible with the 1st Amendment, that the government shouldn't do this, and that legislatures and people who undertake this aren't complying with the letter of the Constitution," [See [Voting](#), A14]



A PRIVATE contractor conducts additional cleanup at a Palisades lot already cleared by the U.S. Army Corps. CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

Blazes' victims allege botched cleanup

Federal efforts to clear debris in Altadena and the Palisades fell short, hundreds say.

By TONY BRISCOE

After January's wildfires reduced thousands of homes in Altadena and Pacific Palisades to heaps of ash and rubble, wildfire survivors hoped federal disaster workers would give them a fresh start on a rebuild-ready lot.

But many residents say that has not been the reality.

More than 800 complaints were submitted to a U.S. Army Corps of Engineers hotline dedicated to the agency's debris removal efforts from March to mid-May, according to public records obtained by the Los Angeles Times. About a third of those reviewed by The Times allege that federal crews either didn't thoroughly remove wildfire debris or failed to follow protocols.

Many wildfire victims complained that remediation was mostly confined to each building's footprint, leaving significant portions of their properties untouched.

In some cases, property owners criticized contractors hired by the Army Corps for leaving behind debris, including car parts, fire-damaged home foundations, hazardous trees and contaminated pool water.

In other instances, they said federal contractors didn't adhere to their own cleanup guidelines. Among the most notable shortcomings: failing to remove ash-covered soil outside [See [Cleanup](#), A6]

L.A. fire deaths might be in hundreds

By all accounts, the January firestorms that decimated thousands of homes and killed 31 people in Los Angeles County were the most devastating in the region's history.

But new research suggests that the Eaton and Palisades fires may have been far more deadly than what's reflected in coroner reports.

A research letter published Wednesday in the *Journal of the American Medical Assn.* estimates the county experienced 440 more deaths than typically expected between Jan. 5 and Feb. 1 — a period that began just days before the fires exploded. This higher number of deaths, the study says, probably reflects such health-damaging influences as increased exposure to poor air quality, or delays and interruptions in health services caused by the fires.

Although the immediate effects of wildfire and other climate-driven disasters are starkly apparent in hard-hit communities, the lingering consequences can be challenging to quantify. Toxic smoke exposure and environmental damage stemming from wildfires can linger months, and even years, after the flames are extinguished.

"Attributing deaths properly to a wildfire is just almost an impossible task," said Andrew Stokes, an associate professor at Boston University and a [See [Firestorms](#), A6]

Research suggests many more than official tally were harmed by smoke, other effects of the January infernos

By HANNAH FRY



A NEIGHBOR braves the heat of a burning house as he tries to prevent a fire from spreading on LaPaz Road in Altadena on Jan. 8. ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

Study exposes 'tide of fraudulent science' making it into print

By NIAMH ORDNER

Fraudulent scientific research is now being produced and published on a large scale, with some unethical researchers colluding with unethical editors to attain the prestige that comes with publication, according to a new study in the *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*.

Large groups of editors and authors appear to have cooperated in what it called "the tide of fraudulent science."

Among their efforts, the researchers who conducted the study obtained about 47,000 retracted articles. They collected reports of the same image used in multiple publications. They compiled 33,000 papers of suspicious origin. Making use of the fact that editors' names are public at some science publishers, they looked at whether some editors handled disproportionate numbers of problematic scientific papers, ones that were later retracted or noted negatively by other scientists.

At the journal *PLOS One*, they were able to link 30.2% of the retracted articles to 45 editors. Of these

editors, 25 had their own papers retracted. The 45 editors represented 0.25% of the total number of editors at the journal. *PLOS One* did not respond to a request for comment.

Researchers also found clusters of articles accepted in less than a month, often involving the same editors and authors.

"They found cases where people submitted papers and those papers got accepted extremely fast, and when you looked at the editors, they were just sending them to each other," said Luis Amaral, a systems biologist at Northwestern University and senior author of the study.

"There are people who believe that there is widespread fraud," said Reese Richardson, a postdoctoral researcher in the Amaral Lab at Northwestern and lead author of the study. "What this paper does is give a method and a starting point and the data to show that this is actually happening, and that the current mechanisms are not equipped to stop it."

The study's findings confirm the suspicions of many researchers, including Elisa [See [Science](#), A7]



A CROSSWALK Collective LA member walks beside a new one in Koreatown. CARLIN STIEHL Los Angeles Times

Angelenos, tired of waiting for city action, paint crosswalks themselves

By COLLEEN SHALBY

The streets around Stoner Park in Sawtelle are often filled with families on their way to the park, nearby day care and surrounding schools. Jonathan Hale, a local resident, believed the area was lacking a key safety feature: designated crosswalks.

Hale recently took it upon himself to make a fix that he believed the city had overlooked when he purchased about \$200 worth of paint and recruited neighbors to

paint crosswalks around the park over several weekends.

It's not the first time Angelenos have taken matters into their own hands to try to improve street safety by painting crosswalks at dangerous intersections. Many get frustrated by how long it takes for the city to respond to requests through 311 and just do the job themselves. Sometimes the city removes the paint stripes; sometimes it moves to make them permanent.

In Sawtelle, Los Angeles' Department of Transportation removed the unsan-

ctioned DIY project about two months after the first stripe was painted, prompting an outcry among community members.

The department said crosswalks needed to comply with accessibility requirements before permanent installation. Then last week, the mayor's office announced that the crosswalks would be painted after all — before curb ramps and sidewalk improvements were made.

"Stoner Park is a key community anchor — a [See [Crosswalks](#), A14]

Apple commits more to the U.S.

By QUEENIE WONG

Apple, which was singled out by the Trump administration earlier this year over its production practices, took a further step to highlight its commitment to boosting investment in the United States.

The tech giant pledged to spend an additional \$100 billion on domestic manufacturing, a move that could ease tensions with President Trump, who wants iPhones built in the U.S.

Apple also said for the first time all of the cover glass on iPhone and Apple Watch units will be made in the U.S. at Corning's Harrodsburg, Ky., manufacturing facility.

"We're going to keep building technologies at the heart of our products right here in America because we're a proud American company, and we believe deeply in the promise of this great nation," Apple Chief Executive Tim Cook said at a White House event.

Trump praised Cook before the tech mogul opened a white box with Apple's logo, showcasing engraved glass before placing it on a base made of gold from Utah.

"This is the largest investment Apple has ever made in America and anywhere else and it's just an honor to have you," Trump said.

Apple said it aims to bring more of its supply [See [Apple](#), A11]

5 soldiers hurt in Georgia shooting

A sergeant is detained. The motive in the attack at Ft. Stewart is unknown. **NATION**, A5

Seeing upside to youth hall seizure

Supervisors are open to a receiver but want the person to confront labor unions. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Disney reports streaming gains

Company reports an increase in subscribers, but theatrical results dipped. **BUSINESS**, A9

Weather
Sunny and hot.
L.A. Basin: 94/68. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

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